

The Self from Anthropological Perspectives

Anthropology

- **Definition:** "The word 'anthropology' is derived from the Greek words anthropos ("human") and logia ("study"). Anthropology is the study of people throughout the world—today, yesterday, and long ago."
- **Subdisciplines of Anthropology:**
 1. **Cultural Anthropology:** "It is also known as 'social anthropology.' It studies the learned behavior of groups of people in specific environments."
 2. **Linguistic Anthropology:** "It is the study of how language influences social life."
 3. **Biological/Physical Anthropology:** "It focuses on human evolution within the context of human culture and behavior."
 4. **Archaeology:** "It interprets human history by analyzing material remains to interpret the experiences and activities of individuals and civilizations throughout history."

The Self and Person in Contemporary Anthropology

- "In contemporary anthropology, studying the self and person involves key aspects."
- "Anthropologists emphasize that norms, values, and social practices culturally shape the self."
- "They explore how individuals perceive themselves and manage their identities within cultural contexts."
- "Social relationships within communities also play a crucial role in shaping self-perception and behavior."
- "Symbols, rituals, and cultural behaviors contribute significantly to forming individual and group identities."
- "Anthropology also examines how globalization and cultural exchange impact identity in diverse societies, influencing how individuals adapt to or resist cultural changes."

The Self as Embedded in Culture

- "In understanding how societies influence the identities we are part of, it is essential to understand the self within culture."
- "Anthropologists Clifford Geertz and Margaret Mead emphasized the importance of not only our characteristics but also our perception of ourselves within the wider cultural context."

Clifford Geertz (1926 – 2006)

- **Overview:** "Clifford James Geertz was an American anthropologist who contributed to his theories of interpretive anthropology and symbolic significance."
- **Symbolic Anthropology:** "Geertz argued that cultural symbols and meanings significantly influence individual identities."

- **Cultural Embeddedness:** "Geertz believed that individuals' sense of self is deeply rooted in cultural contexts. Cultural symbols, rituals, and social norms shape how people perceive themselves and their roles in society."
- **Performance and Interpretation:** "Geertz explored social performance, where individuals express and negotiate identities through interactions and interpretations of cultural symbols. The self is not fixed but is continuously negotiated and expressed through these performances."

Margaret Mead (1901–1978)

- **Overview:** "Margaret Mead was an American cultural anthropologist best known for her studies on cultural relativism, gender roles, and socialization."
- **Cultural Relativity:** "Mead showed how cultures have unique norms and values that shape individual identities."
- **Socialization and Learning:** "Mead explored how individuals learn cultural norms through upbringing and social interactions."
- **Flexibility of Identity:** "Unlike some thinkers, Mead argued that identities are adaptable across cultures."

Summary Comparison

- "In essence, while both Geertz and Mead highlight the cultural construction of self, Geertz's approach focuses on symbolic interpretation and performance within specific cultural settings."
- "In contrast, Mead's perspective explores the diversity of identities shaped by cultural norms and socialization processes across different societies."

The Self from Psychological Perspectives

The Self as a Cognitive Construction

- Our self-awareness is constantly influenced by cognitive processes such as perception, interpretation, and memory.
- It emphasizes the dynamic nature of the individual that features its evolution through personal experiences, beliefs, and social interactions.
- This perspective indicates that our self-concept is flexible and changes as we incorporate new information and reinterpret our experiences, which shape how we perceive ourselves and the environment.

William James' Self Theory ("I" self vs. "Me" self)

- **"I" self:** "This is how we experience ourselves in the present moment, including our thoughts, feelings, and actions. It's about being aware of ourselves as we live and reacting in real time."
- **"Me" self:** "This is the objective part of ourselves, made up of our traits, roles, and how we see ourselves based on past experiences and social feedback. It's more stable and forms our enduring self-image."

Global Model vs. Differentiated Model

- **Global Model:** "This model highlights how traits, values, and self-concept remain consistent across different situations, suggesting that fundamental aspects of the self define one's identity regardless of external factors."
- **Differentiated Model:** "This refers to a psychological and interpersonal theory developed by Murray Bowen, a psychiatrist and researcher in the field of family therapy."
 - **Intrapsychic Differentiation:** "It is when we can tell apart our thoughts from our emotions."
 - **Interpersonal Differentiation:** "It is when we can distinguish our experience from the experience of people we are connected to."

Carl Rogers' Self Theory (Real vs. Ideal Self)

- **Real Self:** "It refers to how individuals perceive themselves currently, including their beliefs, attitudes, and behaviors based on their actual experiences and self-reflection."
- **Ideal Self:** "It refers to the person we aspire to be, reflecting our goals, values, and envisioned accomplishments for personal growth and fulfillment."

David Lester's Theory (Multiple vs. Unified Selves)

- **Multiple Selves:** "Individuals can exhibit different identities or behaviors in various situations or roles."

- **Unified Self:** "It refers to a cohesive identity that integrates various aspects of the self into a harmonious whole."

Donald W. Winnicott's Theory (True Self vs. False Self)

- **True Self:** "It represents the authentic and innate qualities of an individual. It reflects one's core identity and genuine feelings."
- **False Self:** "It refers to a protective persona formed in response to external pressures, expectations, or traumas. It masks the true self to cope with social demands or avoid rejection."

The Self as Proactive and Agentic by Albert Bandura

- **Proactive behavior:** "It refers to self-initiated behavior aimed at addressing problems before they arise."
- **Agentic behavior:** "It refers to the ability to control one's goals, actions, and destinies."

Four (4) Core Properties of Human Agency

1. **Intentionality:** "It refers to setting goals and making plans to achieve something."
2. **Forethought:** "It refers to thinking ahead and planning actions based on expected outcomes."
3. **Self-reactiveness:** "It refers to monitoring and evaluating one's behavior and emotions."
4. **Self-reflection:** "It refers to rewarding or adjusting behaviors based on self-evaluation and feedback."

The Self in Western and Eastern Thought

Individualistic vs. Collective Self

- **Individualistic self:** "refers to a person's identity and sense of worth that is primarily characterized by their unique attributes, preferences, and achievements."
 - Values personal autonomy, self-expression, and pursuing individual goals and aspirations.
 - **Individualistic culture:** "strongly emphasizes personal goals, independence, and self-reliance" and prioritizes "individual rights, freedom of choice, and personal accomplishments over group or collective interests."
 - Examples of countries: The United States of America, Australia, Canada, United Kingdom, and Germany.
- **Collective self:** "refers to a person's identity and sense of worth that is closely tied to their group memberships, relationships, and roles within their community."
 - Prioritizes group harmony and fulfilling communal expectations over individual desires or achievements.
 - **Collectivist culture:** "emphasizes group harmony, cooperation, and the well-being of the community over individual goals" and values "loyalty to the group, interdependence, and shared responsibilities."
 - Examples of countries: Japan, China, South Korea, and the Philippines.

The Social Construction of the Self in Western Thought

- The Western concept of the self is "individualistic, focusing on freedom, choice, and independence from cultural influence."
- It emphasizes "the uniqueness of each person, egoism, and the idea of a distinct self separate from others."
- Individualism stresses "personal goals, self-realization, and autonomy in decision-making."
- It does "NOT advocate isolation but encourages forming relationships based on personal beliefs and judgments."
- People engendered in an individualistic culture might describe themselves in terms of personality traits and characteristics, e.g., "I am brave, generous, loyal, and honest."

The Self as Embedded in Relationships and Through Spiritual Development in Confucian Thought

- **Confucius Background:** "Confucius, born Kongqui in 551 B.C., was China's most influential teacher and philosopher, who has profoundly influenced the Chinese and East Asian civilizations."
- **Confucianism:** Views individuals as part of a larger group rather than separate entities, centering on human relationships as exemplified by the Five Cardinal Relationships (ruler and subject, father and son, husband and wife, elder brother and younger brother, and friends). Harmony is achieved when each person fulfills their duties.

- **Relational self:** "According to Confucius, individual identity is shaped by the group they belong to." Each member shares important traits, takes pride in shared beliefs, and remains united through success and failure.
- **Subdued self:** "It means prioritizing social duties over personal desires." It embodies virtues such as ren (human-heartedness), emphasizing altruism, benevolence, and fulfilling societal obligations.
- In Confucian thought, "the self develops through relationships and spiritual growth," emphasizing "fulfilling social roles, moral cultivation, and harmony with the natural order."